

Part III — The Veil

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

The Step-Daughter names the drama they carry — a moment, she promises, when *we lose this little darling* — and the Mother breaks under it: the faint, the chair, and the veil the Father lifts against her will. Wife and widow at once; the lover dead two months; a son who is his, children who are not. *She isn't a woman, she is a mother.*

Then the money enters the room: a hundred francs in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table, in the back room of a dressmaker's shop — a transaction this town has agreed not to talk about, and “a near thing, though.” The Step-Daughter claims the shame and the revenge in one breath. The room stops being entertained and begins to be implicated; the amber light tightens on the family.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

She seizes the plot's wheel entirely, mapping every turn in advance to leave the Father no corner of the story he can claim.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to Manager]*. Worse? Listen! Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when we lose this little darling, and this fool here *[Seizing the coat off the chair and shaking it.]* does the stupidest thing — you will see me run away. But the moment hasn't come yet. After what has taken place between him and me *[Indicating the Father with a horrible wink.]*, I can't stay here, watching her anguish over that fool *[Indicates the Son.]*. Look at him — frigid, indifferent, because he is the *legitimate* son. He despises us all because we are bastards. *[Goes to the Mother and embraces her.]* And he won't even recognise her as his mother. *Wretch.*

Her body speaks before language can: the arms pulling both children close, then falling, say what no sentence of hers has managed.

THE MOTHER *[to the Manager; one arm tightens around the Child-bundle, the other goes toward the Boy-chair as if to keep both of them upright]*. In the name of these two little children, I beg you... *[She grows faint and is about to fall.]* Oh God!

Chivalry deployed as staging — he rushes forward to help and, in the same motion, casts himself as the scene's moral anchor.

THE FATHER *[coming forward to support her as do some of the Actors]*. Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

Unable to distinguish grief from theatre, the Actors reach for the only category they know and ask whether the collapse is real.

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3. Is it true? Has she really fainted?

He calls for the chair and is already directing — the practical crisis and the scene he wants to shape are, for him, the same thing.

THE MANAGER. Quick, a chair! Here! *[One of the Actors brings a chair, the Others proffer assistance. The Mother tries to prevent the Father from lifting the veil which covers her face.]*

Forcing the Mother's face into public view, he turns her pain into an exhibit that proves his own suffering.

THE FATHER. Look at her! Look at her!

Her 'no' is not modesty; the veil is the last membrane between a private wound and the spectacle the Father is building around her.

THE MOTHER. No, no; stop it please!

Lifting the veil, he borrows her body as evidence — the same appropriation that defined the marriage he is now narrating.

THE FATHER *[raising her veil]*. Let them see you!

| Turning to the Manager, she names for the first time exactly what she cannot bear: being made into testimony in someone else's argument.

THE MOTHER *[rising and covering her face with her hands]*. I beg you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

| Reaching for the tidiest domestic category he knows, the Manager hopes 'wife' or 'widow' will restore the authority this family is stripping from him.

THE MANAGER *[dumbfounded]*. I don't understand at all. Is this lady your wife? *[To the **Father**.]*

| Flat confirmation coated in possessive pride — he claims her still, without noticing that the claim convicts him.

THE FATHER. Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

| The laugh is a defence: the Actors grab the logical absurdity to avoid looking at the emotional reality it floats on top of.

THE MANAGER. But how can she be a widow if you are alive? *[The Actors find relief for their astonishment in a loud laugh.]*

| He needs the room solemn because laughter dissolves the gravity in which his reframing of events can take hold.

THE FATHER. Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

| The cry escapes before she can catch it; the hand at her mouth shows the years of practice she has had doing exactly that.

THE MOTHER *[the cry surprising her — a hand goes to her own mouth, as if to catch it]*. No! No!

| Mourning etiquette deployed as irony — 'most respectable' strips the black clothes of every comfort they were meant to provide.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Fortunately for her, sir, he is dead. Two months ago, as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

| Reclassifying the Mother as a function rather than a person, he erases her desire so that only his philosophical architecture remains standing.

THE FATHER. He isn't here — but not because he is dead. He isn't here because her drama is not a drama of love at all. She felt nothing for either of us — perhaps a little gratitude, not for me, for the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother. And her drama, sir, lies all in these four children she has had by two men.

At the word children, the **Mother's** arm closes around the Child-bundle, before any word comes.

| Breaking her habitual silence, she shifts the grammar from passive to active — 'he gave me' — and for the first time holds the story in her own hands.

THE MOTHER. I had them? Have you got the courage to say that I *wanted* them? *[To the **Company**.]* It was him. He gave me to that other man. He made me go.

| A reflex of loyalty more than an argument; she is fighting a different battle from the Mother and does not notice the difference.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true.

| Two challenges in one breath — the denial and the deeper wound: what can the daughter know of what the mother was made to do?

THE MOTHER *[her hand tightens on the Child-bundle without her noticing]*. Not true? And what can you know about it?

| Her defence of the Father is also self-defence — absolving him keeps the Son's indifference inexcusable and the family wound permanently open.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true. Don't believe it. *[To **Manager**.]* Do you know why she says so? For that fellow there. *[Indicates the **Son**.]* She tortures herself, destroys herself on account of the neglect of that son there; and she wants him to believe that if she abandoned him when he was only two years old, it was because this man *[Indicates the **Father**.]* forced her to it.

One glance upward toward the Son who does not return it, one immediate retreat: the whole arc of maternal failure compressed into a stage direction.

THE MOTHER [voice tight; eyes still on the floor]. He forced me to it. [Silence. No one fills it. For the first time she raises her eyes — to the **Son**. He does not look back. She lowers them again.] And I call God to witness it. [To the **Manager**, still without lifting her head.] Ask him [Indicates the **Father**.] if it isn't true. Let him speak. You [To the **Step-Daughter**.] are not in a position to know anything about it.

The dead father's tenderness is wielded as a weapon; happiness in that house becomes evidence against the Mother's claim of coercion.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I know you lived in peace and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?

Unable to lie about the happiness, she concedes complexity — and the honesty costs her the argument before she can finish the sentence.

THE MOTHER. No, I don't deny it...

Shaking the empty coat as if the dead man could still testify, she lets grief show through the violence of the gesture.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He was always full of affection and kindness for you. [Turning on the Boy-chair, gripping the lapel of the coat as if shaking him by it.] It's true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?

Still loyal to the dead man's memory, she draws a careful line between the act of leaving and any passion that might have excused it.

THE MOTHER. Leave him alone. Why do you want to make me appear ungrateful, daughter? I don't want to offend your father. I have told him: I did not leave my house and my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful passion.

Three words stripped of all philosophical scaffolding — the Father's brevity here is more damning than any speech he has delivered.

THE FATHER. It's true. It was my doing.

His sentence dies when his eyes reach the Mother; real pain crosses into the theatre space and the appetite for spectacle curdles into something else.

PLAYER 1 [to the **Company**, beginning to relish it — then his eyes reach the **Mother**, and the end of the sentence does not arrive]. What a spectacle. What an absolute... [He stops. The treat has gone out of it.]

Quietly, without irony, she marks the inversion: the professionals have been demoted and the family they cannot perform for has become the show.

PLAYER 2 [lower now]. We are the audience this time.

One phrase landing in silence does what a full sentence could not — the absence of laughter proves the normal social release has been shut down.

PLAYER 3 [quietly, the pencil not moving]. For once. [Nobody laughs.]

Leaning forward the way an audience member does when they have stopped pretending not to care, the sceptic is becoming a witness against his will.

THE MANAGER [beginning to get really interested — leaning slightly forward, the way an audience member does when they have started to listen]. Let's hear them out. Listen!

Pre-emptive ridicule is the Son's only weapon: label the philosophy fast enough and perhaps it will not seduce the room before he can stop it.

THE SON. Oh yes, you're going to hear a fine bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

Buried inside the attack is the most honest thing he says — 'the phrase I've found to excuse myself with' — and he covers it immediately with more argument.

THE FATHER. You are a cynical imbecile. [To the **Manager**.] He mocks me for the phrase I've found to excuse myself with.

Monotone repetition performs the very thing it accuses; he too uses a word as a wall to keep the Father's reality at arm's length.

THE SON [without looking up]. Yes. Phrases. Phrases.

Universalising his failure into everyone's condition, he redistributes guilt until no single person can be held to account for anything specific.

THE FATHER. Phrases! And isn't everyone consoled by a word — some simple word that means nothing, and yet calms us?

Two words cut through the whole edifice: she names remorse as the most self-serving consolation word of all, the one that costs least.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Even remorse. Especially remorse.

His insistence that he went beyond words is a setup — the hundred francs is the action he substituted for feeling, and it is coming.

THE FATHER. Remorse? No. It took more than words to quiet the remorse in me.

Making the abstraction sordid and exact, she times the detail of the money to destroy whatever sympathy the Father has carefully built.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, there was money. A nice little bit. The hundred francs he was about to lay down for me, gentlemen — and I two months an orphan. *[A ripple of unease among the Actors.]*

His disgust at her exposure mirrors his own refusal to confront the family's wound; what he calls vile, he also calls too close to home.

THE SON *[to the Step-Daughter]*. This is vile.

With forensic precision she catalogues the shop, forcing the polite euphemism 'robes et manteaux' to carry its real cargo of exploitation and exchange.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Vile? There they were in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table in the back of Madame Pace's shop. You know Madame Pace, sir — one of those *ladies* who take in poor girls of good family on the pretext of selling *robes et manteaux*. The pretext is always *robes*. The arrangement is always something else.

As the shop is named, the Mother draws the Child-bundle up against her and covers its ears with her hand.

The unpaid money becomes a moral paradox: the Father is guilty of the intention even though the act was interrupted, desire proven by the attempt.

THE SON. And he thinks he bought the right to tyrannize over us with that hundred francs. Which — note this, gentlemen — he never got the chance to pay.

Compressed into one ironic laugh: bitterness, survivor relief, and self-contempt — a sound that has nowhere respectable to land.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It was a near thing, though, you know! *[the laugh she means to be ironic does not quite come]*

She turns the Child's face away before she speaks; the words are addressed inward, a reflex to shield innocence from shame already filling the room.

THE MOTHER *[low, not raised; she turns the Child-bundle's face into her shoulder before she speaks — the words are for the bundle, not the room]*. Shame, my daughter. *[A breath. The Step-Daughter's laugh is still in the air.]* Not in front of her.

Claiming ownership of the shame and inverting it into power, she reconstructs the room so exactly that memory becomes re-enactment and the Father cannot intervene.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Shame? Oh, the shame is mine — and the *revenge*. I am dying to live that scene. The room — I see it. Here is the window with the mantles in display, there the divan, a screen, and in front of the window the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs. I can almost take hold of it. But you, gentlemen, might look elsewhere for this part of it. I do not blush, however. *He* does. *[Indicating Father.]*

Pirandello plants the Manager here as a surrogate for the audience — confusion on stage to licence confusion in the house.

THE MANAGER *[the audience's confusion, on stage]*. I don't understand this at all.